for the Tata Group as a whole,' commented an article by INSEAD, the premier French business school.

As Bickson said in an interview in 2005: 'When you are looking to create an international presence, you cannot be in "B" sites. We knew we would have to look for trophy properties and for portfolios that could provide entrée [sic] into key markets. A single transaction such as The Pierre gives us unbelievable visibility. Once we turn around The Pierre, we will be known as a company that can do the job. That opens up tremendous opportunities.'

By 2005, IHCL had sixty-nine hotels in its portfolio, with fifty-five hotels in India and fourteen in destinations such as Mauritius, the Maldives, Seychelles, Malaysia, the UK, the US, Sri Lanka, Bhutan, the Middle East and Africa. In 2006, pursuing Ratan's plan of increasing international presence, the company decided to establish three hotels in South Africa and 'through a subsidiary acquired the erstwhile "W" hotel in Sydney, Australia' in February and 'renamed it as "Blue Woolloomooloo Bay"'.

This was followed by the outright acquisition of the famous Ritz-Carlton in Boston for $170 million in 2007. As Ritz had sold all its interests in the property, IHCL rebranded it as Taj Boston and improved its service. After the change of ownership, the quality and service rendered by the hotel improved so noticeably that it was specially mentioned by Henry Kissinger during my meeting with him. That year, IHCL also bought a 10 per cent stake in the historical Orient Express luxury passenger train for Rs 850 crore. Expanding in the major cities of the US, IHCL acquired the Campton Place in San Francisco. By then, Ratan had increased IHCL's footprint abroad to the extent that 24.6 per cent of its revenue came from its overseas operations. The success of the new strategy was reflected in the increase in the market cap and revenue of IHCL as well. Since Ratan's becoming chairman ten years ago, by 2007 the market cap of the company had increased by nearly 200 per cent and the revenue (consolidated) rose by 189 per cent (2003–2007).

The company continued with its domestic expansion spree and, in September 2010, IHCL launched Vivanta by Taj (following the recommendation Landor made in 2004)—the word carefully chosen to mean active, bright, sprightly. The next year, the company launched five new properties under the Vivanta by Taj brand.